191 Inf Bde/10 Inf Div. Our defences were based on a linear obstacle system called the Ditch-cum-Bund (DCB). The DCB was a relatively new concept that had been introduced after the 1971 war. The Pakistanis had launched a surprise offensive here, spearheaded by their armour and with no obstacle to stop them, swept all the way to Jaurian on the approaches to Akhnoor. It was only due to some determined action by our own reserves that we were able to push them back, but Chhamb remained in their hands. Manning the DCB was therefore crucial to stop any such offensive, and we were supposed to know every kink and bunker of the DCB. Ahead of the DCB and up to the Line of Control (LC) is what is called the Forward Zone, occupied by several posts at the Company and Platoon level. The Company post in our Battalion area was called Sangam, because it was exactly at this point that the LC terminated and the International Boundary (IB) began.

I rejoined at Budhwal after my leave, where the Battalion had just reached about a week earlier. One morning, the CO asked Maj Thyagarajan Muthuswamy (Muthu) and me to go for familiarization with the DCB, walk along its length and identify the various bunkers, their locations, which of them needed repair, areas of the bund that had caved in and needed shoring up and so on. We started off in earnest but about halfway through, Muthu had a great idea. He had been told there were nice fat fish to be found in the waters that flow through the ditch, so why don't we try our luck? With that in mind, he had also carried his fishing rod which he quickly put together, baited it with a piece of roti left over from our mid-day meal and cast the hook into the waters of the ditch. We were sitting thus quite relaxed, dreaming of some nice fish curry for dinner when the CO materialized out of nowhere. Needless to say, there were fireworks, with Muthu getting the

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